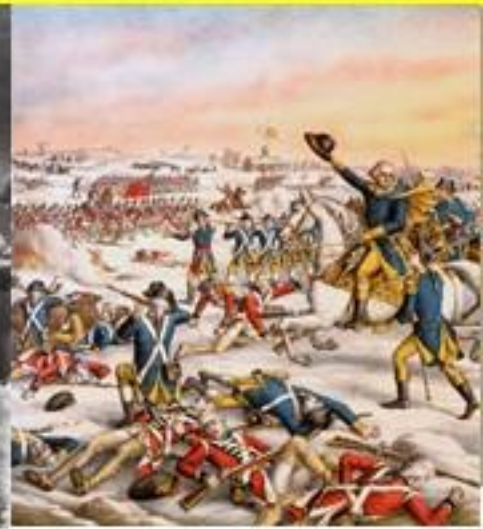


WORLD HISTORY



MODULE - 12

FRENCH REVOLUTION - 1

WHAT IS THE SIGNIFICANCE OF FRENCH REVOLUTION?

- The French Revolution opened a new chapter in the history of Europe.
- It marked a turning point in the history of humankind.
- The French Revolution put an end to the age old absolute monarchy, feudal laws and social inequality.
- It introduced for the first time the idea of republicanism based on "Liberty, Equality and Fraternity".
- These ideas had influenced the entire continent of Europe and also the world.



WHAT ARE THE FACTORS THAT LED TO FRENCH REVOLUTION?

1

POLITICAL CAUSES

- France was ruled by the Bourbon dynasty.
- They firmly believed in the Divine Right theory – as they were representatives of God, they were answerable only to God.



1

POLITICAL ISSUES

LOUIS XIV

- He was a strong and powerful ruler of the Bourbon dynasty.
- His wars ruined the economy of France.
- His successors Louis XV and Louis XVI were weak administrators.



LOUIS XV

- He foretold at the end of his rule: "After me the deluge". His words came to be true.



LOUIS XVI

- He was the most incompetent ruler. His wife and queen, Marie Antoinette interfered too much into the administration.
- She was thoroughly ignorant of the sufferings of the French people. But she always favored and protected the interests of the French nobles.
- She did not allow the financial reforms to take place. Because it affected the interests of the nobles and the clergy.



The French society was based on inequality. The society consisted of three major divisions, the nobles, clergy and the common people.

1 NOBLES

- ✓ The nobles had no political power but remained loyal to the king.
- ✓ They enjoyed many privileges and led a life of luxury.
- ✓ They were exempted from taxation.



2 HIGHER CLERGY

- ✓ The higher clergy owned one fifth of the lands in France and enjoyed several privileges.
- ✓ Their number in France was around only five thousand.
- ✓ They lived in palatial houses and they were exempted from taxes.

LOWER CLERGY

- ✓ But the lower clergy were denied all these privileges.
- ✓ Therefore, they turned against the higher clergy during the revolution.
- ✓ Both the noble and the higher clergy led a life of ease and pleasure without bothering about the wretched condition of the masses.



3 COMMON PEOPLE

- ✓ The majority of the population in France belonged to the third category.
- ✓ Traders, lawyers, owners of industries, government servants, peasants and workers were in this category.
- ✓ While the nobles and the clergy were exempted from paying taxes, the masses paid all the taxes.
- ✓ Hence it was said : “the nobles fight, the clergy pray and the people pay”.
- ✓ The taille or land tax was entirely paid by the peasants.
- ✓ The gabelle or salt tax was a burden on the common man.



3 COMMON PEOPLE

- ✓ The head of each family had to pay the capitation tax.
- ✓ Besides paying these taxes to the king, they have to pay tithe (tax) to the Church.
- ✓ The burden on the peasants was higher than the others because he had certain other obligations to the nobles.
- ✓ They were forced to use the mill, wine-press, slaughterhouse and oven of their lords after paying the usual dues.
- ✓ They were also compelled to render feudal services to the lords.



3

ECONOMIC CAUSES

- 1 The financial condition of France was very critical during the reign of Louis XVI.
- 2 The national debt had increased beyond the limit
- 3 The national income was less than national expenditure.
- 4 Hence, the king tried to mobilize national income by selling important offices of the government.
- 5 At last, the king appointed financial experts Turgot and Jacques Necker as Director-General of Finances.



LOUIS XVI



TURGOT



NECKER

3

ECONOMIC CAUSES

- 6 They tried to curtail royal expenditure and improve the income to the government.
- 7 But their measures did not receive the support of the nobles. On their advice the queen Marie Antoinette removed them.
- 8 Later, Calonne was appointed to look into the financial crisis. But he was not able to do anything but to levy fresh taxes.
- 9 Therefore, Louis XVI was forced to convene the States General after a gap of 175 years, on May 5th, 1789.



MARIE ANTOINETTE

CHARLES DE
CALONNE

WHAT WAS THE PURPOSE BEHIND CONVENING THE STATES-GENERAL?

- 1** The bankruptcy of French treasury was the starting point of the French Revolution.
- 2** Louis XVI was faced with a serious financial situation.
- 3** There was also no alternative but to propose new taxes.
- 4** So, Louis XVI summoned the States General on 5th May 1789.
- 5** The main purpose for summoning the States General was to get its consent for the fresh taxes to be levied upon the people.
- 6** The king also recalled Necker to head the finance ministry.



NECKER

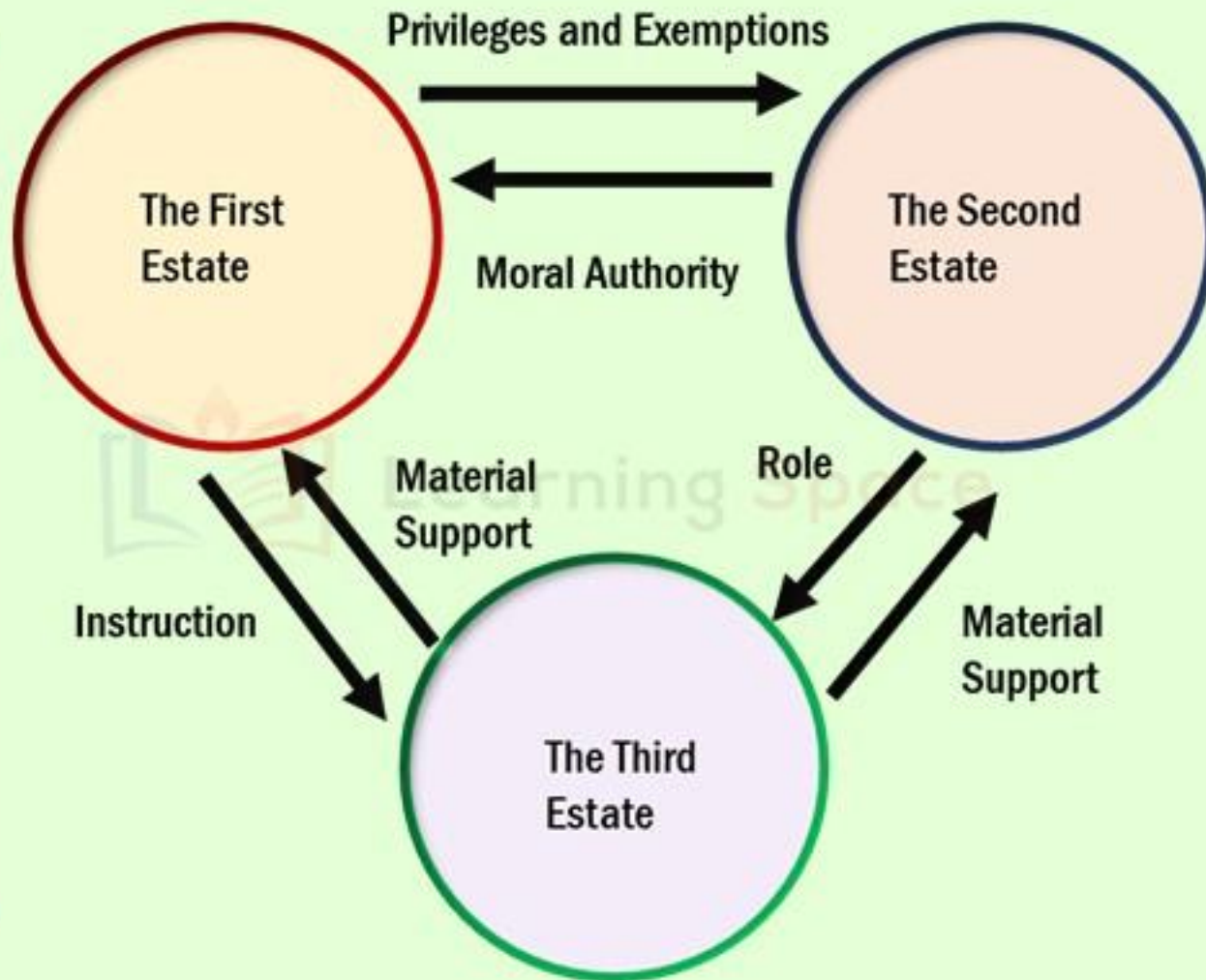
FORMATION OF NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

1 The States General consisted of three Estates Chambers.

2 Three Estates Chambers:

- The First Estate was represented by the Clergy
- The Second Estate was represented the Nobles
- The Third Estate was represented by the Common people.

3 When the king called for its meeting, each Estate sat separately.



FORMATION OF NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

4 However, the members of the third estate demanded a joint sitting and one vote for each member.

5 As the first and second Estates did not concede to this demand, there was a deadlock.

6 On 17th June 1789, the third Estate declared itself as the National Assembly.

7 The king got alarmed and prevented them from entering the hall.

8 But, the members of the National Assembly went to a nearby Tennis Court and took an oath to frame a new constitution. This is known as Tennis Court Oath.



FORMATION OF NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

- 9** On 23rd June 1789, a special session of States General was held.
- 10** The king declared the acts of the Third Estate as illegal.
- 11** He also ordered that the three Estates should meet separately.
- 12** But the third Estate refused to accept the king's orders.
- 13** Hence, Louis XVI submitted to the will of the third Estate, which represented the common people.

- 14** He ordered the three Estates to sit together.

- 15** Thus the formation of National Assembly was completed.



CONTRIBUTION OF THE FRENCH PHILOSOPHERS

- 1 The writings and the preaching of the French philosophers prepared the common people for the revolution. The most prominent among them were Montesquieu, Voltaire and Rousseau.

MONTESQUIEU

- In his book, The Spirit of Laws advocated the constitutional form government.
- He introduced the idea of separation of powers into executive, legislative and judiciary to ensure the effective functioning of democracy.



MONTESQUIEU

VOLTAIRE

- He launched a crusade against superstition and attacked traditional beliefs.
- He wrote many essays, poems and dramas creating awareness among the masses.
- He advocated the supremacy of reason.
- He stood for religious toleration.
- He strongly condemned the corruptions in the church.
- He stood for a benevolent despotism.



ROUSSEAU

- He was the author of the famous book, Social Contract, which was considered the Bible of the French Revolution.
- He said that the real sovereignty rests with the people.
- His famous statement, "Man is born free and is everywhere in chains" kindled the revolutionary spirit of the masses.



CONTRIBUTION OF THE FRENCH PHILOSOPHERS

DIDEROT & D'ALEMBERT

- Published the Encyclopedia. It contained several essays and articles written by revolutionary thinkers.



1 The revolutionary ideas of these philosophers spread throughout France and created awareness among the masses.

2 The French intellectuals gave the motto “Liberty, Equality and Fraternity” which became the watchwords of the revolution of 1789.



WHAT WAS THE IMPACT OF AMERICAN REVOLUTION?

- 1** The independence of the thirteen American colonies from England provided a boost to the French people.
- 2** The French captain Lafayette with his soldiers returned from America after helping the colonies to secure their independence.
- 3** His experience in America along with the fighting spirit for the cause of democracy reached the ears of the French and inspired them.
- 4** Therefore, they decided to put an end to the despotic rule of the Bourbons.



WE EXPRESS OUR
SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

For Information:

info.learningspacedigital@gmail.com

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0866 244 44 72

98499 42299

94415 27588